

Frostbite - Female (Adult)

Algorithm 1038 | Adult (18 years and older) | Gender at birth: Female

Definition

- Cold-exposure/frostbite assessment decomposed from NHS.UK's published when-to-get-help guidance.
- Adult patient.
- Female.

Initial assessment

1. [OPEN_TEXT] What is the person's exact age and sex, are they pregnant, which parts are affected, how long/cold/wet was exposure, is refreezing possible, and are there hard/numb/discholoured/blistered areas or hypothermia signs? Include infant and safeguarding concerns.
2. [DURATION] How long was the caller exposed to the cold?
3. [YES_NO] Has the caller already moved somewhere warm and sheltered?

Triage and redirect questions

1. Redirect → Cold Exposure (Hypothermia)

Is generalized cold exposure, shivering, confusion, drowsiness, or reduced consciousness the main concern?

Systemic cold illness requires the authored Cold Exposure (Hypothermia) pathway.

1. Disposition level 100

Is the skin hard and frozen, is there swelling and loss of feeling in the area, are there blisters filled with blood or milky fluid, or is the person shivering constantly with slurred speech, slow breathing, and confusion?

NHS.UK frostbite guidance lists these as emergency ambulance or Emergency Department criteria, including hypothermia signs (constant shivering, slurred speech, slow breathing, confusion).

1. Disposition level 15

Is this mild cold exposure with tingling or numbness only, already moved to a warm sheltered place, with none of the features above?

NHS.UK guidance describes safe rewarming at home for mild cold exposure without hard/frozen skin, blistering, or hypothermia signs.

Advice

Qatar emergency frostbite/hypothermia response

- Call Qatar emergency services on 999 and do not drive for hard/frozen/numb/discoloured or blistered tissue, suspected hypothermia, confusion, drowsiness, slow/abnormal breathing, an unwell baby, or extensive injury. Move to shelter, remove wet clothing if practical, cover with dry layers, and handle gently. Do not rub, massage, walk on affected feet, use direct heat, or thaw tissue if refreezing is possible. Call Qatar 999 now, follow the call-taker's ambulance and emergency-transport instructions, and do not self-drive. Do not delay emergency care.
- Call Back If: worsening confusion, drowsiness, or floppiness; slow or abnormal breathing; hard, numb, discoloured, or blistering tissue.

Governed care for mild cold exposure without frostbite signs

- Move indoors, remove wet or restrictive clothing/jewellery, dry and wrap in loose warm layers, and protect the area from pressure. Do not rub, use direct heat, hot water, or alcohol. Active water rewarming, pain medicine, dressings, and oral fluids require confirmation that frostbite/hypothermia is absent plus age, pregnancy, comorbidity, swallowing safety, and Qatar pathway checks.
- Call Back If: skin becomes hard, numb, pale, blue, grey, or blistered; confusion, slurred speech, drowsiness, floppiness, or abnormal breathing.

First aid

- Call Qatar emergency services on 999 and do not drive for hard/frozen/numb/discoloured or blistered tissue, suspected hypothermia, confusion, drowsiness, slow/abnormal breathing, an unwell baby, or extensive injury. Move to shelter, remove wet clothing if practical, cover with dry layers, and handle gently. Do not rub, massage, walk on affected feet, use direct heat, or thaw tissue if refreezing is possible. Call Qatar 999 now, follow the call-taker's ambulance and emergency-transport instructions, and do not self-drive. Do not delay emergency care.

References

- NHS.UK, "Frostbite", <https://www.nhs.uk/conditions/frostbite/> (page last reviewed 09 June 2025)

Provenance

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